GinCol Lab · Aula

Student worksheet

Spanish Language and Literature I · 1st year of Bachillerato · How we understand each other · Class 4 of 7 · With Vera

Looking after the other's face: politeness

Class video: https://youtu.be/7GiBWemRfm8

The code leads to the video.

Name: _____ Date: _____

The class is about Spanish, so the examples stay in Spanish, with their meaning in English in brackets.

Before you start: what do you find appropriate?

Someone you don't have a close relationship with invites you to lunch. You say you can't, with an excuse. And that person insists. These are two ways of insisting:

- **A.** «Te digo que te vienes a comer. Cambias las citas o lo que quieras, pero aquí te espero.» ("I'm telling you, you're coming for lunch. Change your plans or whatever, but I'll be expecting you here.")

- **B.** «¿Seguro? A mí no me supone ninguna molestia y me encantaría que vinieras.» ("Are you sure? It's no trouble at all for me and I'd love you to come.")

Which one do you find appropriate? Tick one and explain why in one sentence.

1. Only A.

2. Only B.

3. Both.

4. Neither.

At the end of the class. What did people answer in Jaén and in Coventry? Is your class like either of the two cities? And what can't be concluded from that comparison?

While you watch the video

1. What three things weigh in a request? Answer before Vera says it.

2. Face has two sides. What does each one want? Why doesn't "negative" mean "bad"?

3. Which face does each sentence threaten, negative or positive?

4. «Déjame tus apuntes» ("Lend me your notes").

5. «Tu redacción tiene muchas faltas» ("Your essay has lots of mistakes").

6. «No, no voy a tu cumple» ("No, I'm not coming to your birthday").

7. Thanking and apologising threaten the speaker's own face. Which side of face does each one threaten, and why?

8. The three steps from the previous class (the direct request, the formula and the hint): which of Brown and Levinson's paths do they fall on? And the softeners?

9. About two tenths of a second pass between one turn and the next, and preparing a single word takes at least six. How can that be explained?

10. Before you see the waveform of the nail-painting conversation, write down how much silence you think there will be: _____ seconds. After seeing it: who breaks the silence, and how?

11. In the dance of the offer, what does each step look after: the first "no", the insistence and accepting «un vasito de agua» ("a little glass of water")?

12. Does the Jaén and Coventry survey measure what people do or what they say they find acceptable? Why does it matter for drawing conclusions?

Practice

1. Which face does each sentence threaten, and whose? «¿Me prestas veinte euros?» ("Can you lend me twenty euros?"), «Gracias por traerme» ("Thanks for the ride") and «Has vuelto a llegar tarde» ("You're late again").

2. Write the same request, «cierra la ventana» ("close the window"), along the five paths. And for the fifth, say what you would do.

3. You're invited to a plan you can't go to. Write your answer, as you would really send it, and explain what the other person has to infer and how you look after their face.

The two sentences in "Before you start" are those of a real questionnaire, quoted word for word: F. Fernández García (2023), "¿Acercamiento solidario vs. distanciamiento respetuoso?", *Revista Española de Lingüística Aplicada* 37(1). The English glosses in brackets are ours, not the wording of the study's English version. The other examples on this worksheet are invented.

Keep thinking

If you say «¡Qué pena, no puedo!» ("What a shame, I can't make it!") when you don't really feel like going, are you lying? Is politeness a form of lying? Write down your position and the best reason for the opposite one.

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